There was quite a bit of commentary on what a direct transition from North Block to Mint Street would entail. Y.V. Reddy, my predecessor, had a formidable reputation for standing his ground with the government. The commentariat said that my familiarity with, and sympathy for, the government's point of view would help repair that strained relationship between the ministry of finance and the Reserve Bank. Others thought that my allegiance to the ministry of finance would make me more pliable and I would dilute the independence of the Reserve Bank. Some even suggested that I was being dispatched to implement the government's agenda from within the Reserve Bank.

The media commentary was par for the course and a pointer to the expectations and demands of the job I was getting into. The only bit that troubled me was doubts about my credentials and the suspicion that I would compromise the autonomy of the Reserve Bank. I was aware too that the only way I could counter those doubts and suspicions, and establish my credibility, was by demonstrating my professional integrity in all that I said and did, which would inevitably take time. I had no option but to be patient.

My immediate concern, where I did not have the luxury of time, was to establish my credentials with my staff in the Reserve Bank, as their trust and support would be critical to my performance and effectiveness. More than any other constituency, I had to convince them as soon as possible that all my decisions as governor would be informed by nothing but larger public interest. This would be a daunting addition to my already long list of formidable challenges on the way forward.

Transition from Delhi to Mumbai

I had barely two days to prepare—physically, mentally and emotionally—for this most unexpected turn in my career. I met the finance minister and thanked him for selecting me for this responsible and prestigious position. I called on the prime minister and the conversation went along predictable lines about how he reposed confidence in me and of all the challenges that the government and the Reserve Bank had to jointly address. The prime